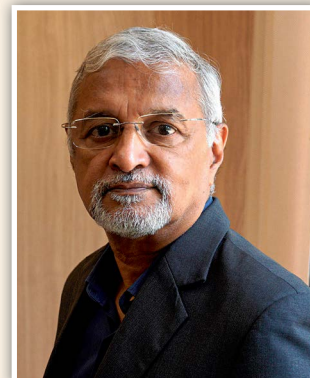




KJSIM STAYS THE COURSE AHEAD OF THE CURVE IN MANAGEMENT STUDIES

Dr Raman Ramachandran, Dean and Director, K J Somaiya Institute of Management (KJSIM), Somaiya Vidyavihar University, Mumbai, Maharashtra, comes with an extensive and rich experience in leadership roles in the corporate world to leverage the institution to a different level. The former CMD of BASF India and recipient of FICCI's Chemical and Petochemical Sector 'Lifetime Achievement Award' 2021, also a certified coach for training senior level executives, is unleashing his passion for management education at KJSIM. Excerpts from his interview.



How would you sum up the essence of K J Somaiya Institute of Management and the values and ethos that have sustained the institution's uniqueness throughout?

The strong ethos and values instilled by our Founder, Padmabhushan Shri. K J Somaiya, have been faithfully carried forward by his son and now his grandson. These principles have profoundly shaped the evolution of Somaiya Vidyavihar, which was established 82 years ago and today encompasses 37 institutions across multiple campuses.

Over the past 43 years, KJSIM has proudly produced nearly 15,000 alums worldwide, embodying the core values of being grounded, principled, and humble. These values capture the essence of the education we provide at our institute.

What is KJSIM's strategy to produce socially responsible leaders and managers of tomorrow that global corporations need to drive social development and sustainability?

KJSIM is a business school with a clear purpose, and our purpose is, 'Transforming, Together', articulated as, Together we enable transformation journeys of individuals to value-based and purpose-driven leaders to build a better world. Through various activities and curriculum on Sustainability, ESG, Circular Economy, our students learn the fundamentals for sustainable and social development.

Students at our Enactus chapter run multiple social development initiatives like *Riwayat*, which focuses on reviving and preserving the art of Warli painting; The *Kruti* initiative aims to transform the lives of underprivileged women through the art of tailoring; *Samridhhi* works towards the problem-solving of organic waste, poor health and hygiene practices; *FinLit* works with disadvantaged sections of the society to equip them with essential financial knowledge. The *Ankur ELI* (Experiential Learning Initiative) helps students to 'Learn by Doing'. Our students also voluntarily organised a *Sustainability Week* on campus to reduce environmental impact by temporarily banning the sale of plastic bottles. And organising international conference on *Sustainability and Waste Management and Circular Economy* gives them an in-depth understanding of sustainability.

What is your thought on the value of experiential learning and skill development, considering the

shortage of skilled workforce in the marketplace?

At KJSIM, we emphasise a balanced approach to education through our Student Progression Index (SPI). In this framework, 50% of weightage is for students' academic performance, while the other 50% is carefully structured to offer a holistic education.

This includes Deep Reflective Learning, where students discuss articles and news with their mentors every two weeks. This allows them to connect classroom learning with the real-world scenarios outside. We encourage students to undertake industry-led certifications, which are highly valued by employers and enhance student's employability. Students also gain valuable experience by participating in competitions, sports and learning from industry leaders through Careers & Conversations.

We also believe, experiential learning gives students a well-rounded management education. Every student takes on summer internship as a part of their MBA journey to gain practical experience. Students are encouraged to undertake international exchange programs, live projects, social impact projects, research projects, capstone projects, and student teaching to complement their academic experiences and prepare them for the professional world.

What's your observation on India's youth making a mark in the start-up ecosystem?

India ranks among countries with the largest number of

successful start-ups, most focusing on business innovation. However, a promising development in the last decade is that science-based start-ups, such as in biotech, space research, and engineering, are increasing. This is something to celebrate because deep science-based innovations and start-ups will eventually help the nation to leapfrog. I hope start-ups continue to proliferate, and it's heartening that the government is very supportive of this ecosystem.

What is the hope, promise and future you see in today's youth of India?

We need leaders who recognise the inequalities present in the world and work to reduce these disparities when they are in positions of responsibility. I am proud to say that our students at KJSIM show this consciousness and have implemented student-led initiatives for various causes. It is encouraging to see that many young people today understand these challenges and are committed to doing what is right.

India is rapidly accelerating toward becoming one of the world's top three economies, and our youth is at a unique and advantageous point in our country's economic growth journey. This is their time to seize the many opportunities before them. I hope – and fully expect – that they will make us proud by growing into responsible individuals who give back to the planet more than our generation has taken, leaving behind a world better than they inherited.

